

Copilot Studio vs. Microsoft Foundry

A high-level guide to choosing the right platform for building AI agents and solutions in the government cloud — and why it's often both.

Bottom line These platforms are **complementary, not competing**. Reach for **Copilot Studio** to build agents fast with low-code and extend Microsoft 365; reach for **Microsoft Foundry** to build custom, developer-led AI on your choice of models. Many government solutions use both together.

Two platforms, different strengths

Microsoft Copilot Studio

Low-code · SaaS

- **Build fast** — design, test, and publish conversational and task agents with a visual canvas and natural language.
- **Extends Microsoft 365** — surface agents in Copilot, Teams, SharePoint, and the web.
- **Connected** — 1,000+ prebuilt connectors and Power Platform integration reach into business systems.
- **Governed** — managed through the Power Platform admin center with DLP and managed environments.
- **Maker-friendly** — fast time-to-value for business teams and IT.

Microsoft Foundry

Pro-code · PaaS

- **Full control** — a unified Azure platform to build custom AI apps and agents, code-first.
- **Model choice** — pick from a broad catalog of models (including Azure OpenAI) with fine-tuning and evaluations.
- **Advanced orchestration** — multi-agent workflows via SDKs and a large tool catalog.
- **Enterprise-ready** — built-in tracing, observability, and responsible-AI guardrails.
- **Scales & publishes** — managed runtime; publish agents to Microsoft 365, Teams, or your own apps.

Lean toward Copilot Studio when...

- You want speed and low-code, maker- or business-led delivery.
- The need is a conversational or task agent — citizen self-service, employee help desk, FAQ.
- You're extending Microsoft 365 Copilot, Teams, or SharePoint.
- You want prebuilt connectors into existing business systems.

Lean toward Microsoft Foundry when...

- You need a custom, code-first AI application or agent.
- You want to select or fine-tune specific models for the use case.
- You need advanced orchestration, custom tools, and deep Azure integration.
- Developers or data scientists own the AI logic and lifecycle.

In the government cloud (GCC)

Both platforms are offered in Microsoft's US government clouds, keeping data and processing within the United States.

US data residency

Copilot Studio (GCC) and Foundry (Azure Government) keep customer content within US government cloud boundaries.

Compliance

Copilot Studio GCC aligns to FedRAMP High; Foundry runs in Azure Government (US Gov Virginia & Arizona).

Security & governance

RBAC, DLP and managed environments, private networking, and responsible-AI guardrails.